THE TURNCOAT BRIGADE

In this 'poaching season', several Punjab leaders have entered the fray after crossing over to rival parties. Here are a few sitting/ former MPs and MLAs from this league



RAVNEET SINGH BITTU
BJP, *Ludhiana*
A three-time **Congress** MP from Anandpur Sahib (2009-14) and Ludhiana (2014-24)



PRENEET KAUR BJP, *Patiala*
Patiala MP, suspended from the **Congress** for 'anti-party activities' last year. Was elected in 1999, 2004 and 2009 as well

SUSHIL KUMAR RINKU BJP, *Jalandhar*
Won Jalandhar Lok Sabha bypoll as **AAP** candidate in 2023. Was earlier **Congress** MLA from Jalandhar West (2017-22)





RAJ KUMAR CHABBEWAL AAP, *Hoshiarpur*
Incumbent two-time MLA from Chabbewal in Hoshiarpur district, elected both times (2017 and 2022) on a **Congress** ticket

GURPREET SINGH G.P.
AAP, *Fatehgarh Sahib*
Was a **Congress** legislator from Bassi Pathana (2017-22)

PAWAN KUMAR TINU
AAP, *Jalandhar*
Former two-time **SAD** legislator from Adampur (2012-2022)

MOHINDER SINGH KAYPEE
SAD, *Jalandhar*
Former **Congress** MP from Jalandhar (2009-14)/ three-time MLA/ PPCC president

DHARAMVIR GANDHI
Congress, *Patiala*
Former **AAP** MP from Patiala (2014-19), floated his own party in 2019

JEET MOHINDER SINGH SIDHU Congress, *Bathinda*
Elected MLA four times as **Independent/ Cong./ SAD** nominee (2002-17)

minister Som Parkash, the ticket has been given to his wife, Anita, to keep the support intact.

When it comes to 'poaching', the strategy is to welcome Sikh leaders with a history of moderate stances and deep Dalit antecedents. Manjit Singh Mianwind, a Mazhabi Sikh Dalit, for instance, who crossed over from the Akali Dal ahead of the 2022 assembly election, and is fighting from Khadoor Sahib, a general seat. "The BJP," says Ashutosh Kumar, a political science professor at Panjab University, Chandigarh, "is expected to do much better in urban centres by peeling away potential voters from the AAP and the Congress."

SAD: Battle for Survival

The saffron party's old ally, the Akali Dal, too, has fielded Brahmin candidates like N.K. Sharma in Patiala and BJP turncoat Anil Joshi in Amritsar, hoping to gain traction in urban centres. For SAD chief Sukhbir Singh Badal, the Lok Sabha election presents perhaps the last chance to restore his party's relevance. In 2019, they managed to win only two seats—Sukhbir himself in Ferozepur and his wife Harsimrat in Bathinda—and hit rock bottom with just three seats in the assembly polls. This time, while Sukhbir has withdrawn from contesting, Harsimrat will try and retain her seat. However, her chances in Bathinda have been dented by the BJP fielding Parampal Kaur Sidhu, daughter-in-law of Akali veteran Sikander Singh Maluka, who until this announcement was in charge of Harsimrat's campaign.

Both the BJP and the AAP have been regularly poaching Akali Dal leaders to stymie Sukhbir's revival efforts. Sukhbir was the first to kick off the campaign with his statewide 'Punjab Bachao Yatra' (Save Punjab Tour) in February, hoping to capitalise on the AAP's waning influence over rural Panthic voters. Regaining the trust of this core group is the biggest challenge for the Akali Dal after the 2015 sacrilege and police firing incidents that took place during its reign. Despite his repeated apologies for those incidents and their aftermath, Sukhbir found his party had lost the plot entirely in the elections held thereafter.

There have also been allegations of the Badals and their coterie concentrating power in their own hands while ignoring the Panthic leadership. To make amends, of the 14 candidates (including in Chandigarh) that the SAD has fielded this time, 11 have Panthic credentials. While staying away from the election himself, Sukhbir has also resisted the pressure to field other party elites, like his brothers-in-law Adesh Partap Singh Kairon and Bikram Singh Majithia, and former five-time state legislator and minister Parminder Singh Dhindsa, who has just returned to the party.

In a last-ditch attempt, the SAD chief even tried to return to the National Democratic Alliance (NDA), but the BJP shut that door, citing his adamant stance on pushing for the release of convicted Khalistani militants, including the killers of former chief minister Beant Singh. On March 26, Jakhar announced the breakdown of the alliance talks, and the same afternoon, the BJP inducted Beant Singh's grandson and Congress MP Ravneet Singh Bittu into the party. With Punjab going to the polls only in the final phase, on June 1, the churn is expected to continue for some time. ■